PROMISE & PRACTICE · DEEP DIVE · SOURCE ANALYSIS

First Bull Run — A House Divided

Why They Thought It Would Be Easy

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about First Bull Run — A House Divided, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. Historians judge the past by what people knew at the time, not by what we know now. Step into the summer of 1861

THE SOURCES

THE IMAGE · JULY 1861 — The Battle of Bull Run



This bright, heroic lithograph was sold to a public that still imagined war as a gallant adventure. The reality on the road back to Washington looked nothing like it

"Battle of Bull Run, July 21, 1861" — hand-colored lithograph, Currier & Ives, 1861, public domain (Library of Congress).

SOURCE A · A NORTHERN NEWSPAPER · JUNE 1861 — "Forward to Richmond!"

"The Rebel Congress must not be allowed to meet there on the 20th of July. By that date the place must be held by the National Army. … Forward to Richmond!"
— New-York Tribune, June 1861. Public domain

— New-York Tribune, June 1861. Public domain.

SOURCE B · A WASHINGTON DIARIST · AFTER THE BATTLE — The view from the retreat

> *“The further they ran, the more frightened they grew. … We called to them, tried to tell them there was no danger, called them cowards … but it would not do; they had only one idea — to get away.”*
> *— eyewitness account of the retreat, 1861. Public domain*

— eyewitness account of the retreat, 1861. Public domain.

YOUR WORK

QUESTION 1 STEP 1 · THE MOOD BEFORE

Using Source A and the lesson, describe the mood in the North before the battle. What did people expect, and why were enlistments only ninety days?

QUESTION 2 STEP 2 · JUDGE THEM IN CONTEXT

Contextualization asks us to judge people by what they knew at the time. In 1861, why was it reasonable — not just foolish — to expect a short war?

- ☐ A. because the South had already surrendered
- ☐ B. because no one had yet seen a modern industrial war, so one decisive battle seemed likely to end it
- ☐ C. because the two sides were actually friendly
- ☐ D. because the telegraph guaranteed a quick peace

QUESTION 3 STEP 3 · THE TURN

Use Source B. How does the reality of the retreat clash with the expectations from Source A? Quote one phrase that shows the gap between the two.

QUESTION 4 STEP 4 · WHY IT MATTERS

In two or three sentences: how did the shock of Bull Run change the way the North prepared for the rest of the war? Why does a nation's expectations about a war matter so much?

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — First Bull Run — A House Divided

QUESTION 1: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Before Bull Run, Northerners expected… They enlisted for only 90 days because…"

QUESTION 2: **Correct — B. because no one had yet seen a modern industrial war, so one decisive battle seemed likely to end it**

Right. No one alive had seen an industrial war on this scale. With no modern example to learn from, both sides reasonably — if wrongly — expected one big battle to settle everything.

QUESTION 3: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Source A expected…, but Source B shows…. One phrase is "…"."

QUESTION 4: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "After Bull Run the North…, which matters because…"